Lesson 16: Pronunciation: Stress Review and Intonation in Statements and Questions

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 2.3: Review- Counting Syllables and Identifying Stress; 2.4: Intonation- Statements and Questions.

In this lesson

First you review syllables and word stress with 18 words from Andy's interview (Lesson 15). Then you learn how your voice goes up or down at the end of statements, wh- questions and yes/no questions. At the end you record yourself asking 15 interview questions.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Count the syllables in words from this unit and divide the words into syllables.
- Find and say the stressed syllable in each word.
- Use falling intonation at the end of statements and wh- questions.
- Use rising intonation at the end of yes/no questions.
- Record interview questions with the correct intonation.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
syllable	a part of a word with one vowel sound; one "beat"	wa·ter has 2 syllables
word stress	the syllable that is longer, louder and higher than the others	com·PU·ter
intonation	the music of your voice: it goes up or down	Where did you grow up? (↘)
rise (↗)	the voice goes up at the end	Are you a vegan? (↗)
fall (↘)	the voice goes down at the end	What's your job? (↘)
statement	a sentence that gives information	He drives a pickup truck. (↘)
wh- question	a question with what, where, when, why, who or how; it asks for new information	Why do you like your job? (↘)
yes/no question	a question you can answer with "yes" or "no"	Do you have a car? (↗)
sus·TAIN·a·ble	can continue without being used up	Wind energy is sustainable.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
en·vi·ron·MEN·tal	about the natural world (air, water, land)	the environmental impact of airplanes

Rules and explanations

Syllables (review)

- A syllable is one beat of a word. Each syllable has one vowel sound. Tap the table once for each syllable.
- Count vowel **sounds**, not vowel letters. "pollutes" has three vowel letters (o, u, e) but only two vowel sounds: pol·LUTES.
- The book's example: computer = 3 syllables = com·pu·ter.

Word stress (review)

- In a word with two or more syllables, one syllable has the main stress. Say it longer, louder and a little higher: com·PU·ter.
- The other syllables are short and quiet.
- Stress can change the word. In this unit, "produce" is a noun (fresh fruit and vegetables): PRO·duce. The verb "to produce" (to make) is pro·DUCE.

Intonation: the book's three rules

1. **Statements:** the voice usually **falls** at the end. He drives a pickup truck. (↘)
2. **Wh- questions** that ask for new information: the voice usually **falls** at the end. What's your name? (↘)
3. **Yes/no questions:** the voice usually **rises** at the end. Do you have any pets? (↗)

How to know which question it is

- A wh- question starts with a question word: what, where, when, why, who, how.
- A yes/no question starts with a helping verb: do, does, did, are, is, was, have, can...
- In exercise 3, each one-word question is the last word of a longer interview question. Think of the full question. "Car?" is the end of "Do you have a car?", a yes/no question, so it rises (↗). "Job?" is the end of "What's your job?", a wh- question, so it falls (↘). One-word answers ("yes.", "farmer.") are statements, so they fall.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has no /p/ sound. Say /p/ as in "pen", not /b/ as in "bag", in "repair", "podcasts", "pollutes", "impact", "production" and "pets". - In Standard Arabic a syllable does not begin with two consonants, so learners sometimes add a vowel. Keep consonants together: "pr" in pro·DUC·tion, "str" in in·DUS·tri·al.

Practice

1. Syllables and stress (book review). For each word: (a) write the number of syllables, (b) divide the word into syllables, (c) write the stressed syllable in CAPITALS. Say each word aloud and tap the syllables. Example: computer: 3: com·PU·ter 1 sustainable; 2 industrial; 3 agriculture; 4 values; 5 harvest; 6 repair; 7 produce (noun: fruit and vegetables); 8 podcasts; 9 challenging; 10 vegan; 11 water; 12 environmental; 13 impact (noun); 14 production; 15 pollutes; 16 fences; 17 carbon; 18 habitats

2. Watch. Watch "Rachel's English - Questions and Intonation: Up or Down?" (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Aoj4HZlLQBY). Pause after each question she says and copy her voice.

Exercises 3 to 6: the audio. Each exercise has a sound clip from the book. Play it from the folder E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\02.04-intonation-statements-and-questions\ or from the book's web page (link at the end). Listen, write "rise" or "fall", then repeat each item.

3. End-of-sentence intonation (book). Clip: End_of_Sentence_intonation.m4a. Does the intonation rise or fall? 1 car? (example: rise); 2 yes.; 3 pets?; 4 no.; 5 job?; 6 farmer.; 7 free time?; 8 cooking.

4. Intonation and questions (book). Clip: Listening_Practice_-_Intonation_and_Quesitons.m4a. Rise or fall at the end?

1. What's your name? (example: fall)
2. Where did you grow up?
3. Where are you living now?
4. What's your job?
5. What do you do each day?
6. Why do you like your job?
7. What do you not like about your job?
8. Why is your job important to you?
9. What do you like to do in your free time?
10. Do you have any pets?
11. Do you have a car?
12. Are you a morning person?
13. Do you eat meat?
14. Are you a vegan?
15. What does that mean?
16. Why are you vegan?

5. Yes/no questions (book). Clip: Intonation_in_Yes_No_Questions.m4a. Rise or fall? 1 Do you have any pets? (example: rise); 2 Do you have any brothers or sisters?; 3 Do you have a car?; 4 Are you a morning person?; 5 Do you eat meat?; 6 Are you a vegan?; 7 Do you have children?

6. Wh- questions (book). Clip: Intonation_in_WH_questions.m4a. Rise or fall? 1 What's your name? (example: fall); 2 Where did you grow up?; 3 Where are you living now?; 4 What do you usually eat for dinner?; 5 What's your job?; 6 Why do you like your job?; 7 What do you like to do in your free time?

7. Ask and answer. Ask your tutor the questions in exercises 5 and 6, one at a time. Then ask the tutor to ask you the same questions. Answer in full sentences, with falling intonation.

8. Write. Write 3 new yes/no questions and 3 new wh- questions (the book asks for "why" questions) to ask your tutor. Do not copy any questions from this unit. Mark each one ↗ or ↘. Then ask them.

9. Recording (book, 15 points). Record yourself with your phone asking these questions. Use the correct intonation. Listen back and give yourself one point for each correct question. What's your name? / Where did you grow up? / Where are you living now? / What's your job? / What do you do each day? / Why do you like your job? / What do you not like about your job? / Why is your job important to you? / What do you like to do in your free time? / Do you have a car? / Are you a morning person? / Do you eat meat? / Are you a vegan? / What does that mean? / Why are you vegan?

Speak with your tutor

- "Say a word from Andy's interview. I will tell you how many syllables it has and which syllable is stressed. Then tell me if I am right."
- "I will ask you 10 questions to get to know you. For each one, tell me: is it a wh- question or a yes/no question, and should my voice rise or fall at the end?"
- "You are a new neighbour. Interview me with 5 wh- questions and 5 yes/no questions, one at a time. Then I will interview you with my own questions. Correct my question grammar."
- "Let's play a guessing game. You think of a job. I can ask only yes/no questions, like 'Do you work outdoors?', to guess the job."
- "Give me 5 yes/no questions. I will change each one into a wh- question about the same topic, for example 'Do you have a car?' to 'What kind of car do you have?'"

Read aloud

1. com·PU·ter, sus·TAIN·a·ble, AG·ri·cul·ture
2. en·vi·ron·MEN·tal, HAB·i·tats, pro·DUC·tion
3. What's your name? (↘)
4. Where did you grow up? (↘)
5. Why are you vegan? (↘)
6. Do you have any brothers or sisters? (↗)
7. Are you a morning person? (↗)
8. Do you eat meat? (↗) No. (↘)

Watch online

- Rachel's English, "Questions and Intonation: Up or Down?": https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Aoj4HZlLQBY
- The book's page with the four sound clips for exercises 3 to 6: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/02%3A_Getting_to_Know_You/2.04%3A_Intonation-_Statements_and_Questions

Answer key

1. (checked with the CMU pronouncing dictionary)

#	Word	Syllables	Divided, with stress
1	sustainable	4	sus·TAIN·a·ble
2	industrial	4	in·DUS·tri·al
3	agriculture	4	AG·ri·cul·ture
4	values	2	VAL·ues
5	harvest	2	HAR·vest
6	repair	2	re·PAIR
7	produce (noun)	2	PRO·duce
8	podcasts	2	POD·casts
9	challenging	3	CHAL·leng·ing
10	vegan	2	VE·gan
11	water	2	WA·ter
12	environmental	5	en·vi·ron·MEN·tal
13	impact (noun)	2	IM·pact
14	production	3	pro·DUC·tion
15	pollutes	2	pol·LUTES
16	fences	2	FEN·ces
17	carbon	2	CAR·bon
18	habitats	3	HAB·i·tats

2. No written answer: watch, pause and copy her voice.

3. (book) 1 car? rise; 2 yes. fall; 3 pets? rise; 4 no. fall; 5 job? fall; 6 farmer. fall; 7 free time? fall; 8 cooking. fall. "Pets?" ends "Do you have any pets?" (yes/no: rise). "Free time?" ends "What do you like to do in your free time?" (wh-: fall).

4. (book) 1 to 9: fall (wh- questions). 10 to 14: rise (yes/no questions). 15 and 16: fall (wh- questions). (The book's answer sheet for this exercise leaves out number 14, "Are you a vegan?"; its yes/no answer sheet gives "rise".)

5. (book) All rise: they are yes/no questions.

6. (book) All fall: they are wh- questions.

7. No written answer: a speaking task with your tutor.

8. (example answer) Can you speak French? (↗) Do you like music? (↗) Did you sleep well? (↗) Why do you want to help students? (↘) Why is English important? (↘) Why do people learn languages? (↘)

9. (book answer sheets) Questions 1 to 9: fall (↘). Questions 10 to 13: rise (↗). Questions 14 and 15: fall (↘).

My notes